



camcorder test



Like cameras camcorders can also have either CCD or CMOS sensors

is worth. Sadly, Canon's MRPs are not indicative of street prices and you could probably find this camcorder for a good deal less. As it stands, it's a very capable HD 1080i camcorder; but thanks to this atrocious pricing it loses out on any sort of recommendation.

CANON HF11 Black Beauty

In stark contrast to its sibling, the HF11 is a pure black colour with the finish alternating between matte and glossy black. It has really nice contours and reminds one of designer gear. The quality of surface treatment and materials used is top notch, perhaps even better than the HG20. It's slightly smaller than the HG 20 and features 32 GB of flash memory inbuilt. However, despite its slightly more compact dimensions, it's no worse to hold. Despite the size, Canon has made sure to take care of ergonomics – the record button is placed perfectly for both small and large handed people and you'll find the button conveniently located under the pad of your thumb. The zoom is variable and super slick. Gently nudge the zoom switch and the focus zooms in ever so slowly and slickly. Push the switch harder and the focus zeroes in more quickly – this is one of the best zooms we've used.

As with the HG20, there is an easy button that disables all the extra options and settings for newbies. The click dial is placed on the side of the device and not on the rear as with the HG20. Thus you may not be able to use it one handed and using this dial sometimes requires the use of the other hand. As with the HG 20, there is a mini horseshoe connect provided for using an add-on flash. The LCD viewfinder is crisp and quite clear – however the colour saturation seems to be a little poorer, and this makes the HG20's viewfinder appear a little crisper. Unlike the HG20 that features a 60-GB hard drive, the HF11 comes with 32 GB of flash memory.

The OIS system works very well, and at the long end of the zoom there is barely any shake. In fact, the OIS system is marginally better than the one on the HG20, noticeable at the maximum optical zoom (12x). Image quality indoors is also good; in fact its every bit as good a performer as the

HG20 and we could hardly tell the videos apart. No surprise then when we found it priced identically – Rs. 95,995, equally atrocious pricing on Canon's part. With the current era of aggressive marketing, Canon has a refreshingly different view – chase away consumers with exorbitant prices – mission successful.

SONY HDR-CX100 Petite

The CX100 gets full marks for being the most compact of HD 1080i cameras that we've seen. However this compactness comes at an cost to its ergonomic scores. The fit and finish of this camcorder is good, with Sony following a matte black finish that really sets the tone for a serious device. Parts of the body have a glossy finish. Canon's HF11 looks better, however, and probably sported the highest quality of build in our test. The controls on the Sony are touch-screen based and the menu system is very easy to use. Everything seems designed with newbies in mind, and the menus are very simple; unfortunately for expert users this means a lot of the



Sony HDR-CX100

settings are not as visible.

There's an Easy button that totally idiot-proofs the settings and when activated this button glows with a blue-LED. This camcorder has a smart battery and the viewfinder has a small indicator of the battery life remaining based on the current usage. This is really helpful. The LCD viewfinder is bright with good colours and is more than adequate for most shooting, although it gets a bit dim in bright sunlight. The camcorder powers on when the display flap is opened, although it can also be turned off via a power button located inside this flap.

We found Canon's system of having a power button on the outer body more convenient. As further examples of idiot-proofing, record quality has four preset settings, the lowest having a bitrate of 5 Mbps and the highest using a whopping 16 Mbps; this highest mode records at 1080i. The record button is rather annoyingly close to the grip and people with large hands will have to bend their thumbs. This is irritating, and becomes painful after some time.

There is no click dial to select video / audio and capture and play modes as with most camcorders. Instead, there is a small button that toggles between still image and video. Thankfully, the photo button is conveniently located and has a nice soft feedback. The OIS system works well, although it is not as effective as the OIS system on its larger sibling, the Sony HDR XR-100E. As a result, a little arm jiggling has this camcorder lose its composure faster. However, for the 10x zoom most people will find little to complain about when it comes to blur while shooting.

Once again the zoom is variable – it's super slow or lighting fast depending on finger pressure. Sony's performance in terms of video quality is really good. Sadly, the great performance when shooting in daylight conditions is not repeated indoors and the HDR-CX100 isn't as good indoors, where a bit of noise and loss of detail mar the 1080i videos that it produces.

Priced at Rs. 36,990, the Sony HDR-CX100 is a lot of camcorder for the price and if you're hunting for a super compact, HD camcorder this has to be the one. It's easy to use and very well priced. If the ergonomic issues associated with its compactness don't bother you, then this is the one for you. If they do, you'll find the Sony HDR XR-100E a slightly better camcorder in all respects.

CANON HG10 When young is not better

The cheaper sibling to the HG20, the HG10 is built equally well and follows the same colour scheme as its pricier sibling. The grey / silver colour looks really neat and although we felt this unit was a little large, we couldn't fault the quality of fit and finish. It feels rugged in-hand, something that most large camcorders cannot boast. Canon has got the ergonomics right once again, and the HG10 feels very comfortable; the record button really comes slap bang under the pad of your thumb when properly gripped – perfect. While the record button has a nice soft touch, the photo button is slightly tackier and it's easy to get a bit of camera shake while using it. The HG10 comes with a 40-GB HDD which is enough for at least 200 hours of recording at a resolution of 1080i.

The HG10 actually has a slightly larger CMOS sensor than the ones on the HG20 and HF11, and we expected better results. Moreover, larger CMOS sensors are cost-



Canon HF11



Canon HG10